Q. There has been a trilateral meeting of sorts between India, France and Australia. Do you see this emerging—maybe you could have an acronym for it—as a new grouping?

A. I leave it to you to find a proper word for it. But you are right, the trilateral will take place at the ministerial level in New York at the margins of the UN General Assembly and the change of government in Australia puts France and Australia on a much better cooperation track and we're building trust. We have had difficulties that prevented us from acting jointly in the Pacific as we could. Such action has to be multidimensional—with India, Japan or, say, with Korea. We aim to be more active and to act together.

> **"Environment can be a focus area for India at the G-20. Climate change is a reality and will have a socio-political impact. The issue is key to our future"**

Q. And would that include defence, or trade? What are the areas, because you've had the Quad, the AUKUS... where would this particular grouping stand?

A. I would focus on the cooperation we already have on the seas, which can be extended within the framework of a strategic dialogue with high-level meetings taking place at the end of November. There will be a maritime dialogue aiming at exploring what we can do further together.

Q. The other area of concern is Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Both President Macron and Prime Minister Modi have had dialogues with President Putin. Is there anything that you think these two countries could do together to persuade Putin to work out a diplomatic resolution to this?

A. We do hope that we can not only convey the right messages but also convince the president of Russia to change his behaviour. If I go back to the basics, it's a difficult situation. Russia decided to use aggression towards an independent and sovereign country. So, we cannot put the two countries on an equal footing. Now, we know the differences in our relations vis-a-vis Russia and we do respect that. But there is something that President Macron and PM Modi do, and that is very necessary—talk to every party and, namely, the Russian president and convince him that there must be a political solution to the conflict down the road. There must be a change of attitude in the Russian behaviour vis-a-vis Ukraine, and the opening of a true, sincere and honest dialogue to settle their differences. In the meantime, let me be very honest, we choose to support Ukraine because we need to balance the situation they're in, so they can reach a point where a dialogue would be on a better footing for them. And we must not forget what is at stake here. It's not only the future of Ukraine or the suffering of the Ukrainian people, but an attack on the basic values India and France share and an attack on the core principle of the UN charter. And if we let it go there, it'll be difficult for everyone in the world. Because everyone is watching, including some countries you named. So, what is at stake here is equilibrium in the world—a rules-based order based on law, democracy and mutual respect.

Q. India has had good relations with Russia. There has been criticism from some quarters over India continuing to trade with Russia. How does France view this situation?

A. We know the history of India's ties with Russia and we do respect India's decision to keep some relations going. France has decided with the EU countries to progressively stop its dependency on Russian energy. We did it with coal—it was over in August—it will soon be done for fuel, where it will be reduced by 90 per cent by the end of the year. Every single day, we are reducing the amount of our dependency, which also reduces Russia's ability to fund its war efforts. Finally, we will have to do this for gas too, some of us [EU states] are really dependent on Russia for this—not so much France, by the way. We have found new suppliers and down the road we will have to tell them you chose the wrong path and we have to act as we do and you have to stop this war and come back to peace and dialogue.

Q. India is taking over as the president of the G-20 later this year. What should be our prime focus areas?

A. If I were to pick just one among the many issues, I'd say the environment. Climate change is a reality, it will affect the poorest of the world most and drive up inequalities. This will have social and political consequences. The issue is key to our future. Whatever India might be willing to do to fight this as G-20 president, we will be there at its side to help.

Q. You have also talked about PM Modi's 'lifestyle for environment' mission.

A. Yes, it was a brilliant idea that came up last year at the Glasgow COP26 summit. France is interested in the initiative and, hopefully, PM Modi will now be able to promote it at the G-20, and even share it with the rest of the world. It is needed.

Q. For Indian students wanting to study in France, there are still issues of visas, mobility, migration.... Is there a plan to speed up processes, is there good news for students?

A. On the visa front, there is a huge backlog; due to the pandemic, we could not move at the same pace. We are doing our best to catch up. On the students' side, our arms are wide open and they are all welcome. France is not only a country of culture, but also a place to study science and technology, political science.... Our goal is to have 20,000 Indian students coming over in three years' time, by 2025. But we really have to speed up on this. ■